THE UNIVERSITY OF WESTERN AUSTRALIA

Using Artificial Intelligence Tools at UWA: A Guide for Students

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Developed by the UWA Learning and Assessment Design team, Library, and Academic Skills Centre

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Introduction

What is Artificial Intelligence (AI)?

Artificial intelligence (AI) refers to digital systems that are capable of performing complex tasks that previously required human intelligence to complete, such as learning, reasoning, information synthesis, analysis, and problem-solving.

AI tools have been used to support learning at universities for many years. Spell-checkers, email spam filters, search engines, speech-to-text tools, and recommendation systems all use AI algorithms to help us get things done at university.

What is Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI)?

Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) is a subtype of Artificial Intelligence (AI) that uses deep learning algorithms to generate new content from existing sources. GenAI creates new content in response to user inputs called 'prompts.' Recently, GenAI tools such as ChatGPT, Microsoft Copilot, Claude, and Google Gemini have become prominent and commonplace for use at universities.

What can GenAI do?

GenAI is able to create numerous types of content, including:

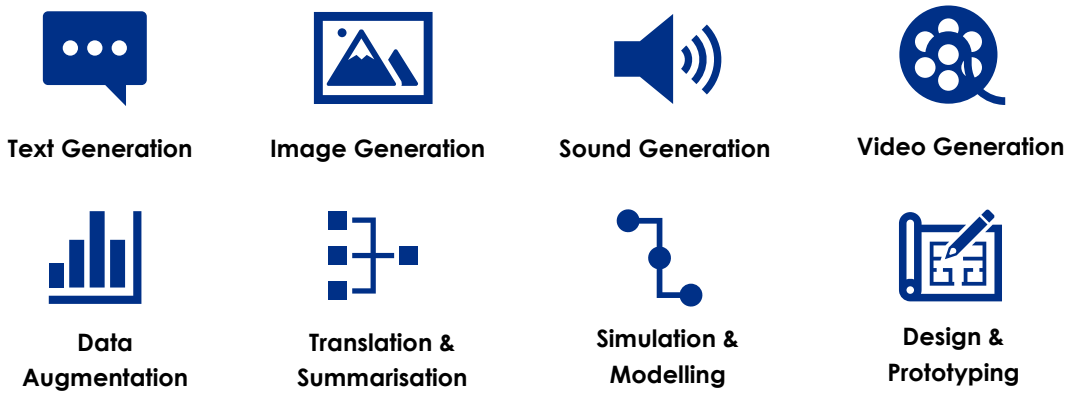

Figure 1. Visual based on an image generated by Microsoft Copilot using the prompt "create a visual representation of the types of outputs and functions GenAI can produce."

GenAI tools have many legitimate uses to help us learn and study. A fundamental principle that guides what we all do at university is another type of AI: **Academic Integrity**. At UWA we think of this as acting with the values of *honesty, trust, fairness, respect* and *responsibility* in learning, teaching, and research. When using AI tools at university we need to act in accordance with these values.

Using AI Tools at UWA

Students must follow their unit coordinators' guidance on the permitted uses of AI tools for completion of coursework and assessments. Guidelines for each unit and assessment may be different, so it is important that you read each of your unit/assessment outlines to understand what is required and permitted.

Can I use AI tools for research and study?

UWA's Academic Integrity Policy allows for the limited use of AI as educational and study tools. You can use AI to assist in your research, study, and for broad editorial assistance in your writing, subject to the explicit permission of your unit coordinator or coordinating supervisor (in the case of higher degree by research students). Importantly, the policy stipulates that **AI tools must not be used as a replacement of your critical thinking and analysis skills**.

Can I use AI tools to complete my assessments?

Permitted uses of AI tools to complete assessments varies from unit to unit and assessment to assessment. **You are required to follow your unit coordinator's guidance on the permitted uses of AI for each assessment item**. Your unit coordinator will outline acceptable and unacceptable uses of AI for each assessment using **AI-use tiers** and/or **AI-use statements** in your unit and assessment outlines. Make sure to read your unit coordinator's guidelines carefully to understand what is expected.

UWA's 3 tiers of AI use in assessments

UWA recently introduced a three-tier guideline for permitted AI use in assessments. These tiers are outlined below.

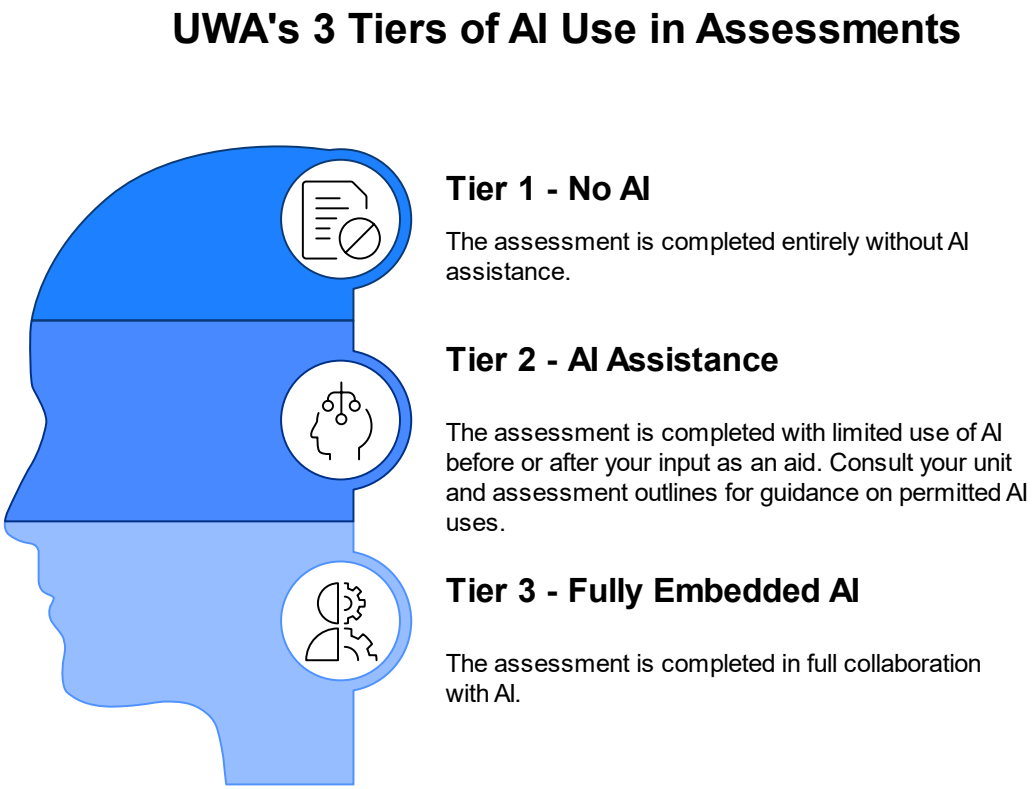

Figure 2. Image generated using NapkinAI from the prompt "Tier 1 - No AI (The assessment is completed entirely without AI assistance). Tier 2 - AI Assistance (The assessment is completed with limited use of AI before or after human input as an aid). Tier 3 – Fully Embedded AI (The assessment is completed in full collaboration with AI)."

Your unit coordinator **may** assign an AI-use tier to your unit's assessments. If they do, the tier they assign and the accompanying AI-use statement provides you with clear guidance on what constitutes permitted and unpermitted use of AI to complete your assessment. Refer to the AI Use in Assessments Guide, your assessment's AI-use statement, and any instructions provided by your unit coordinator before beginning your assessment.

Reading AI-use statements

AI-use statements further define permitted and unpermitted uses of AI when completing your assessment. They may be included to clarify expectations aligned with your assessment's AI-use tier, or may be used in place of a tier.

When you read your assessment's AI-use statement, make sure to identify:

- **The AI-use tier assigned** (if your unit coordinator has assigned a tier)
- **What AI use is permitted** (which tools you are permitted to use and/or how AI tools are permitted to be used)
- **What AI use is not permitted** (which tools you are not permitted to use and/or how AI tools are not permitted to be used)
- **Why you are or are not permitted to use AI tools**
- **How you are expected to reference your use of AI** (how you are expected to reference AI-generated content and any AI tools you used to complete your assessment)

These pieces of information are identified in the below example of an AI-use statement for a research essay.

AI-use tier – In this example, the research essay has been assigned AI-use Tier 2 – meaning AI tools can be used for limited, specified purposes.

Why you are/are not permitted to use AI tools – In this example, use of AI tools supports your research skills. However, to develop your academic writing skills, AI tools should not be used to write your essay.

"*This assessment is assigned AI-use Tier 2. In order to support your understanding of research methodologies and information literacy, you may use GenAI tools for research assistance, and to generate and workshop ideas for your essay. In order to develop your academic writing and critical analysis skills, you are not permitted to use GenAI tools to write any part of your essay. Any work submitted for assessment must be the student's own, and any prompts used by the student to assist in conducting their research should be referenced and submitted for review by the marker.*"

What AI use is permitted
In this example, AI can be used only for research assistance and brainstorming.

Referencing requirements
In this example, students are required to reference and submit for review any prompts they use.

What AI use is not permitted
In this example, AI tools cannot be used when writing the assessment.

Tier 1 – No AI

If your assessment is assigned Tier 1, **you are not permitted to use AI in any way to complete the assessment**. In Tier 1 assessments, security is essential to assure your learning. Therefore, any use of AI for Tier 1 assessments constitutes academic misconduct. There may be controls such as invigilation or proctoring put in place for Tier 1 assessments to ensure secure conditions are maintained.

Students may still use AI tools to support their research, study, and revision in preparation for a Tier 1 assessment. Please refer to your unit coordinator for guidance on the appropriate use of AI tools for this purpose.

Tier 2 – AI assistance

If your assessment is assigned Tier 2, **you may use AI tools for limited and specified purposes outlined by your unit coordinator to complete the assessment**. In Tier 2 assessments, AI tools can be used before or after your input to assist you to complete the assessment. This means that the majority of the work should be completed by you, and AI tools may be used as specified by your unit coordinator for assistance.

Some examples of Tier 2 assessments are outlined below, but please note that there may be other examples that you encounter in your units. It is important to review your unit and assessment outlines to understand what AI use is permitted and not permitted by your unit coordinator.

- Example 1 – AI use permitted for idea generation and brainstorming

In some Tier 2 assessments, you may be permitted to use AI tools to help you brainstorm and generate ideas for your assessment. Your unit coordinator may outline specific AI tools that you are permitted to use, or otherwise may allow you to use any suitable tools of your choosing.

Additionally, your unit coordinator may allow you to use AI for brainstorming and idea generation throughout the entire assessment, or only for specific sections of the assessment.

When completing this type of Tier 2 assessment, you may choose to use GenAI tools to develop a focus for your assessment by prompting them to generate key words and concepts related to a chosen starting theme. As another example, you may choose to use an AI tool to mind map, brainstorm, or visualise your ideas to help you plan your assessment.

When using AI tools for idea generation and brainstorming, make sure to keep a record of all prompts you have used and outputs that were produced in case you need to reference them as part of your submission.

- Example 2 – AI use permitted for research assistance

In this type of Tier 2 assessment, you may be permitted to use AI tools to support your research. Several AI tools exist that specifically support academic research, such as Perplexity AI, Zotero, and Scopus AI. You may be permitted to use these tools to search, review, summarise, and organise research content, and/or to collate and present your bibliography.

While it is helpful to use AI tools to find relevant sources and sort through a large amount of content quickly, AI tools can sometimes make up sources themselves (called 'hallucination') or misinterpret their conclusions. Because of this, you should still read and assure the authenticity of each source AI tools refer to.

Additionally, AI tools are limited in their ability to critically analyse and compare sources, so you still need to read and analyse each source to ensure the summary and claims AI makes about each source are accurate. This also enables you to develop deeper connections between sources, which is something AI tools struggle to do.

Many AI research tools track and store libraries of reference sources that have been cited as part of its search. Make sure to keep a record of these sources, any prompts you used, and outputs that were produced in case you need to reference them as part of your submission.

- Example 3 – AI use permitted for structuring and editing assistance

In this type of Tier 2 assessment, you may be permitted to use AI tools to help you structure and edit your work. There are several ways in which you can use AI

tools to support your writing, and depending on your Unit Coordinator's instructions, you may choose to use AI before or after you have begun writing.

As an example, you may choose to write a rough outline of information, topics, or ideas you wish to focus on in your assessment and then use GenAI tools to help you determine an appropriate structure. If your assessment's AI-use statement permits, you may also choose to use GenAI tools to develop scaffolds and templates to help you structure your assessment.

AI tools can also be used after you have written part or all of your assessment as an editing tool. Several AI tools exist that specifically support grammar, spelling, and written communication, as well as generic Large Language Models (LLMs) such as Microsoft Copilot or ChatGPT. If permitted, you may choose to use these tools to proofread your spelling and grammar, to reword your writing to convey a different tone, and to restructure your writing for flow and coherence. When editing non-textual Tier 2 assessment items, you should purposefully prompt AI to perform specific edits or changes which you have considered thoughtfully, rather than performing random or non-specific changes.

When using AI tools for structuring and editing assistance, make sure to read your assessment's outline and AI-use statement to understand what is permitted. Importantly, **this example of Tier 2 assessments does not permit you to use AI tools to generate content or to create large sections of your assessment**. You should use AI tools only to edit or restructure your own work. Make sure to keep a record of all prompts you have used and outputs that were used in your assessment in case you need to reference them as part of your submission.

➢ Example 4 – AI use permitted for assessment presentation

In this type of Tier 2 assessment, you may be permitted to use AI tools to present your assessment. Depending on your unit coordinator's instructions, you can use AI tools in several ways to design your final product for assessment.

There are several AI tools that can be used to take your written content and present it in different formats, including slideshows, visuals, video and audio, and other non-written formats. Consult your assessment's outline and AI-use statement to determine the format in which you may present your assessment and how AI may be used.

Importantly, Tier 2 assessments of this kind do not permit you to use AI tools to generate new content to include as part of your assessment. You should only use AI tools to present your own content. Make sure to keep a record of all prompts you have used and reference all AI outputs that were used in your assessment.

- Example 5 – Student critical evaluation of AI output

In this type of Tier 2 assessment, you may be permitted to use AI tools to complete a task or section of a task, after which you will be required to critically analyse and evaluate the output generated. As an example, you might be permitted to use AI to complete a data analysis of a given dataset, after which you might be required to analyse and critically evaluate the output produced by the AI tool you used.

In this type of Tier 2 assessment, you will be assessed primarily on your analysis and critical evaluation of the output generated by AI. However, you may still be required to reference and submit the AI generated outputs on which you base your critical analysis, and unless your unit coordinator specifies otherwise, you should not use AI tools to complete the critical evaluation itself.

Tier 3 – Fully embedded AI

If your assessment is assigned Tier 3, you may use AI throughout your assessment to support your own work. When completing Tier 3 assessments, you are enabled to take a collaborative approach with AI tools, and may use them in a variety of ways to complete your assessment. However, this does not mean that AI can be used to complete your entire assessment without your input and evaluation. You are still required to demonstrate your learning and you are fully responsible for the content of your assessment. Your unit coordinator will outline how they expect this to be evidenced.

As an example, you may encounter a Tier 3 assessment in the form of a final project for your unit or degree. Depending on the assessment's outline and AI-use statement, Tier 3 permits you to use AI tools in authentic and professionally-relevant ways in order to plan, complete, and present your assessment.

Below is an example of an AI-use statement for this type of Tier 3 assessment.

AI-use tier – In this example, the project has been assigned AI-use Tier 3 – meaning AI tools can be used collaboratively to complete the assessment.

Why you are/are not permitted to use AI tools – In this example, use of AI tools aligns with professional work contexts, but your reflective and analytical skills need to be assessed without AI use.

"This assessment is assigned AI-use Tier 3. To prepare you to engage in industry projects in authentic ways, including using a range of available AI tools in a professional context, you are permitted to use any appropriate AI tools collaboratively for, among other purposes, research assistance, data analysis, product development, and project management. However, in order to develop and assess your professional competencies, your reflective practice, and your critical analysis skills, you should not use AI tools to complete the entire project without your input and critical engagement, and any sections of your assessment involving critical analysis or reflection should be completed primarily by you, with AI use permitted only for editing assistance. Students are required to reference all AI-generated content included in their final submission. Students are also required to submit an appendix that records all instances in which AI tools were used during the completion of the assessment, including all prompts used and AI outputs produced."

What AI use is permitted – in most Tier 3 assessments, a range of appropriate AI tools can be used without restriction to complete the assessment.

Referencing requirements
In this example, AI-generated content must be referenced and a separate appendix evidencing all AI use must be submitted.

What AI use is not permitted
In Tier 3 assessments, AI tools cannot be used to complete the entire assessment without your critical input or reflection.

What if there is no AI-use tier assigned to my assessment?

Your unit coordinator may not assign an AI-use tier to your assessments. If your assessment does not have an AI use tier assigned, you must follow your unit coordinator's instructions on the accepted and unaccepted uses of AI use for completion of the assessment. This will be outlined in your unit and/or assessment outlines.

If you are unsure about which AI tools you can and cannot use in your assessments and for what purposes, you can contact your unit coordinator to ask for clarification.

Considerations When Using AI Tools

There are several considerations students should keep in mind while using AI tools during their time studying at UWA. Some key aspects of AI use for completing your units are outlined below.

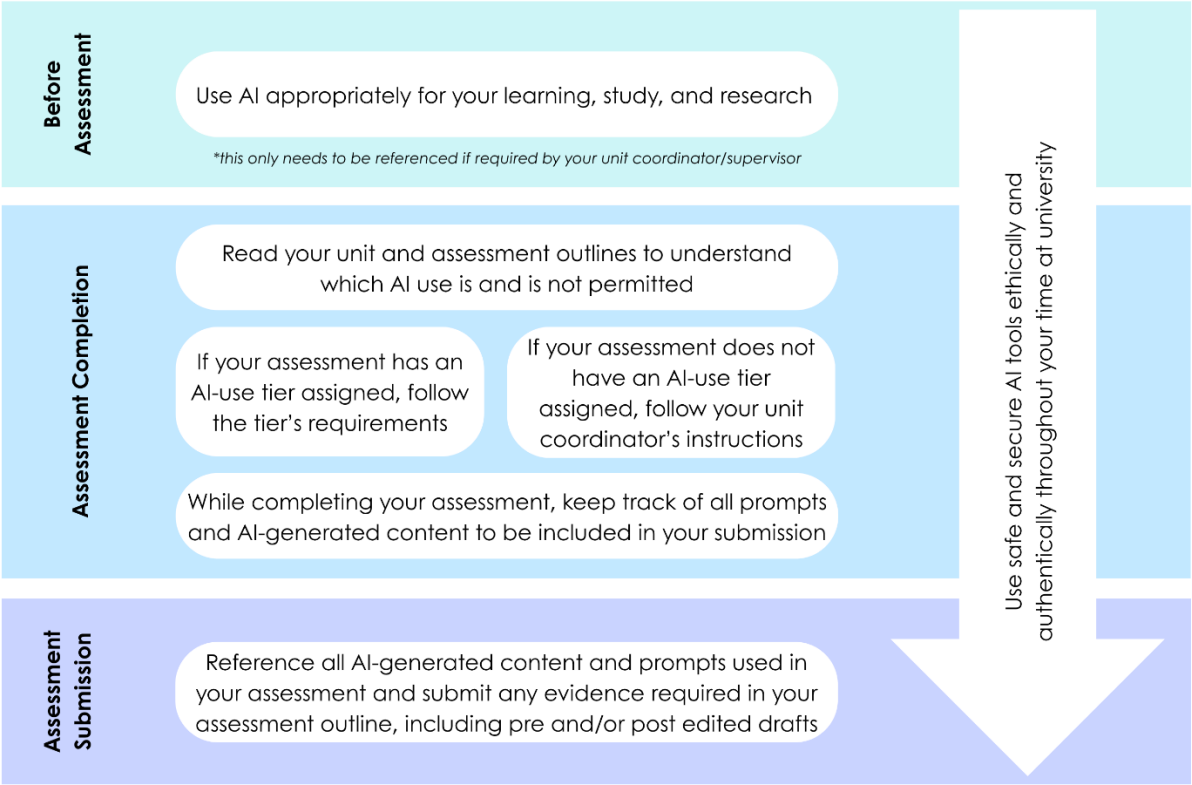

Figure 3. Visual representation of considerations of AI use while completing units at UWA, created using Canva.

How do I write effective prompts for AI tools?

All outputs generated using GenAI begin with a prompt. The quality of the prompt that you use will determine the quality of the output you receive. Depending on the level of sophistication and detail you are looking for, you will need to construct your prompts with enough information and specific parameters to ensure the AI tool you are using generates a useful and accurate response.

The UWA Library has created a detailed guideline for prompting AI tools effectively called **PROMPT-ED**. You can learn more about PROMPT-ED here.

How do I reference and acknowledge the AI tools I've used with permission in my assessment?

First, you must check how and when you are permitted to use AI tools in your assessment; ensure you check your unit outline and assessment guidelines carefully for instructions. If you have paraphrased or directly quoted AI-generated content, you will need to provide an in-text and end-text reference as you would when citing any other sources; this includes both text and image outputs.

You cannot submit for assessment any work that is not your own. Under UWA's Academic Integrity Policy, plagiarism is defined as occurring when "the source of paraphrased material is not cited; quoted material is cited as if it were paraphrased; and quoted material not cited". This policy explicitly includes intentionally or unintentionally using AI and Generative Pretrained Transformer (GPT) language as if it were your own as a form of plagiarism.

Check your unit outline to confirm which referencing style you are expected to use for your unit. The Library has guides for all the referencing styles used at UWA and provides guidance on how to reference and acknowledge AI outputs. If you have any questions about referencing visit the AI Guide: Acknowledge & Reference AI, or the Referencing at UWA guide for general referencing support. You can also ask a librarian here.

Academic misconduct

Improper use of AI-generated material in assessment can be grounds for academic misconduct. For assessments where the unit coordinator has explicitly permitted the use of AI tools, UWA's Academic Integrity Policy states that there are several things you must also do when using AI-generated material:

i. it must be appropriately cited and referenced, along with any other sources used;
ii. it must be clear what AI tool was used and where in an assessment AI-generated material is used;

iii. it is the responsibility of the student to check the accuracy of all information generated by AI study tools; and
iv. it must be ensured that the final product is the student's own work, creation and analysis, and not just copied from an AI generator.

Remember, there is no time limit on when an occurrence of academic misconduct can be detected. This means that even if improper use of AI is not detected at the time of submission, it can be in the future, and misconduct penalties can be applied retrospectively, including after you graduate.
If you are unsure about whether you are doing the right thing, you can speak to the Academic Skills Centre or ask your unit coordinator or tutor.

Privacy, copyright, and AI

Students at UWA should not input any personal data or information into any public AI systems (such as ChatGPT, Google Gemini, and other similar systems). This is because most AI tools will retain user inputs for future use as training data, as well as for other purposes. Once you input your own data or personal information into an AI system, you may lose control over who has access to it and how it is used. It is also important that you do not input any intellectual property or copyright material that is not your own, including the intellectual property of UWA or its staff – such as lecture slides, handouts, and unit reading material – as it is not yours to distribute.

Additionally, not all AI platforms are safe to use. The Department of Home Affairs has raised concerns on the safety and security of data shared with the AI tool *DeepSeek*. As such, **UWA staff and students must not use *DeepSeek* in any way.** UWA has blocked the use of DeepSeek on all University-managed networks and devices, and students should avoid using DeepSeek on their personal devices.

Who can I talk to if I'm not sure?

Unit Coordinator & tutors

Each unit you take may have different rules about using AI Tools in their assessments. Read your unit outline and assessment instructions carefully, and contact your unit coordinator or ask your tutor to clarify anything you're not sure about. You can find their contact details in the Unit Outline on LMS.

Academic Skills Centre

UWA's Academic Skills Centre provides free academic advice, support, and resources for all students at UWA. They can help you to understand academic integrity principles and develop the writing, research, English language, maths and stats skills you need to excel in your university studies. Find out about drop-ins, consultations, workshops, after-hours advice, and online resources on the ASC website.

University Library

Our Library AI guide provides information and advice on AI, or visit one of UWA's five libraries or the University Library online to access a wide range of services, study spaces, information, and help with research, referencing, and copyright support. Ask a librarian here.

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